

MISSION REBUILD™ Glossary

Key Terms — Military, VA, Financial, Identity & Course-Specific

How to use this glossary: If a term comes up in the course and you don't know it, look it up here first. These definitions are written in plain language — no unnecessary jargon, no fluff. Cross-referenced where relevant.

A

Active Component

The full-time, regular military force (Army, Navy, Marine Corps, Air Force, Space Force, Coast Guard). Distinguished from Reserve Component (Guard and Reserve). *Transition note: Active component veterans often find the civilian adjustment sharper than Guard/Reserve veterans who maintained civilian employment throughout service.*

AFSC (Air Force Specialty Code)

The Air Force's system for identifying a service member's job or career field, equivalent to the Army's MOS or Navy's NEC/rate. Used in the civilian translation context to describe specialized skills. *Transition note: See the ONET Military Crosswalk to translate your AFSC into civilian job categories.**

ATS (Applicant Tracking System)

Software used by employers to automatically screen, rank, and filter resumes before a human reads them. Most large companies use ATS. *Transition note: Veterans often have highly qualified resumes rejected by ATS because of military jargon and non-standard formatting. Every resume must be optimized for ATS — use keywords from the actual job posting, standard section headings, and avoid tables or graphics.*

APFT (Army Physical Fitness Test)

The Army's former physical fitness test consisting of push-ups, sit-ups, and a 2-mile run, scored by age and gender. Replaced by the ACFT (Army Combat Fitness Test) in 2022. *Transition note: Your APFT scores and physical culture from service are assets — don't let the absence of mandatory PT lead to a physical decline.*

Asset

Anything you own that has monetary value: cash, investments, real estate, vehicles, business equity. Distinguished from a liability (what you owe). *Transition note: Building assets is the primary wealth-building mechanism taught in MISSION REBUILD. A job provides income; assets build wealth.*

ACP (American Corporate Partners)

A nonprofit that provides free mentorship from corporate professionals to veterans. One-year program. *See the Resource List for details.*

B

BAH (Basic Allowance for Housing)

A monthly non-taxable allowance provided to service members to cover housing costs when government quarters aren't provided. Calculated based on pay grade, dependency status, and duty station ZIP code. *Transition note: Veterans using the GI Bill receive a housing allowance modeled on the BAH of an E-5 with dependents, calculated on the school's ZIP code. This can be significant income — optimize your school choice accordingly.*

BAS (Basic Allowance for Subsistence)

Monthly non-taxable allowance for food, paid to all service members not in basic training or provided meals by the government. *Transition note: When calculating what your military total compensation actually was, include BAH and BAS — the civilian salary equivalent is typically 20–30% higher than your base pay alone.*

Boundary

A personal rule that defines what behavior you will and will not accept from others, and what behavior you will and will not engage in. Not a wall — a boundary communicates your standards and limits while maintaining connection. *Transition note: Military culture often develops either rigid command-and-control boundaries or no personal boundaries at all. Civilian relationships require active, communicated boundary-setting that the military never trained.*

BRRRR

Buy, Rehab, Rent, Refinance, Repeat. A real estate investment strategy that allows an investor to recycle their initial capital by pulling it back out through a cash-out refinance after the property value increases from the rehab. *Transition note: Veterans with discipline and project management skills are well-suited to the BRRRR strategy. Requires access to initial capital and a strong local contractor network.*

BRS (Blended Retirement System)

The military retirement system for service members who entered after January 1, 2018, which combines a smaller defined benefit pension ($2.0\% \times \text{years} \times \text{average high-36 pay}$) with government TSP matching contributions. *Transition note: If you're under BRS and leaving before 20 years, roll your TSP into an IRA and keep contributing. The pension multiplier is smaller but the TSP matching is real money.*

Buddy Statement

Also called a lay statement (VA Form 21-10210). A written statement from someone who has personal knowledge of a veteran's condition or circumstances, used to support a VA disability claim. *Transition note: Buddy statements from fellow service members who witnessed your injury, exposure, or behavior changes can be decisive in claims that lack strong medical evidence.*

C

C&P Exam (Compensation & Pension Examination)

A medical examination ordered by the VA to evaluate a veteran's service-connected disability claim. The examining provider assesses the severity of the condition and its relationship to military service. *Transition note: The C&P exam is one of the most important events in your claims process. Prepare thoroughly — bring your military medical records, personal statement, buddy statements, and private nexus letter if applicable. Do not minimize your symptoms on the day of the exam.*

Cash Flow

The net money moving into or out of your account after all expenses are paid. In real estate: monthly rent income minus mortgage, taxes, insurance, vacancy, and repairs. Positive cash flow = money left over each month. Negative cash flow = you're paying to own the property. *Transition note: Veterans often confuse income with cash flow. High income with high expenses produces no lasting wealth. The goal is to build positive cash flow that requires decreasing amounts of your active time.*

Chapter 31

See **VR&E (Vocational Rehabilitation & Employment)**.

Chapter 33

See **GI Bill (Post-9/11)**.

Chapter 35 (DEA — Dependents' Educational Assistance)

VA education benefit for dependents (spouses and children) of veterans who are permanently and totally disabled due to a service-connected condition, or who died in service or from a SC condition. *Transition note: If you are rated P&T, your eligible dependents may use this benefit — often overlooked.*

Civilian Operating System (COS)

A MISSION REBUILD course term. Refers to the unspoken rules, cultural norms, communication styles, and social dynamics that govern civilian professional and social environments. Veterans often arrive in civilian life without this operating system and must deliberately learn it. *The military had an explicit OS — rank, regulations, orders. The civilian OS is implicit and often frustrating to learn.*

COE (Certificate of Eligibility)

A document issued by the VA confirming a veteran's eligibility to use the VA Home Loan benefit. Required by lenders before issuing a VA-backed mortgage. *Transition note: You can apply for your COE through eBenefits or have your lender pull it directly using the Automated Certificate of Eligibility system. It can often be issued immediately.*

COLA (Cost of Living Adjustment)

An annual increase to VA disability compensation and other federal benefits to account for inflation. Tied to the Social Security Administration's CPI calculations.

Combat-Related Special Compensation (CRSC)

A benefit that allows military retirees to receive both their full military retirement pay and their VA disability compensation for combat-related disabilities, reducing or eliminating the offset that normally applies. *Transition note: Distinct from CRDP (Concurrent Retirement and Disability Pay). Know which one you qualify for before assuming you have to take a reduction.*

Concurrent Receipt

The ability to receive both military retirement pay and VA disability compensation without offset. For most retirees, if rated 50%+ disability, CRDP (Concurrent Retirement and Disability Pay) applies automatically and phased out the offset beginning in 2004.

D**DD-214 (Certificate of Release or Discharge from Active Duty)**

The official document that proves a veteran's military service record, discharge characterization, and eligibility for veteran benefits. The most important document a veteran has. *Transition note: Get multiple certified copies. Store them in multiple locations. Certain employers, VA programs, schools, and states require this document. Replacing a DD-214 can take months — don't lose it. Request additional copies through the National Archives at [archives.gov/veterans/military-service-records](https://www.archives.gov/veterans/military-service-records).*

DEA (Dependents' Educational Assistance)

See **Chapter 35**.

Debt-to-Income Ratio (DTI)

A percentage calculated by dividing your total monthly debt payments by your gross monthly income. Lenders use DTI to evaluate creditworthiness. A DTI under 36% is generally preferred; VA loan guidelines allow up to 41% (though exceptions exist). *Transition note: High DTI from student loans, car payments, or credit cards can block you from VA home loan eligibility. Paying down debt before applying improves your position.*

Defense Finance and Accounting Service (DFAS)

The agency that processes pay and benefits for military members, retirees, and their families. *Transition note: Contact DFAS if you have pay errors, issues with final military pay, or questions about military retirement.*

Disability Rating

See **VA Disability Rating**.

Discharge Characterization

The formal characterization on your DD-214 indicating the nature of your separation. Types include: Honorable, General (Under Honorable Conditions), Other Than Honorable (OTH), Bad Conduct Discharge (BCD), and Dishonorable Discharge. *Transition note: Veterans with OTH or worse discharges may be denied VA benefits. Discharge upgrades are possible — contact a Veterans Law attorney or VSO for guidance. The VA has separate standards for mental health-related misconduct discharges under the "liberal" consideration policy.*

Domiciliary Care

Residential rehabilitation care provided by the VA for veterans with medical, psychiatric, or psychosocial problems who don't require hospital-level care. An underutilized resource for veterans in crisis.

DTI

See **Debt-to-Income Ratio**.

E

E-1 through E-9

Enlisted pay grades in the U.S. military. E-1 (Private, Seaman Recruit, Airman Basic) through E-9 (Sergeant Major of the Army, Master Chief Petty Officer, Chief Master Sergeant). *Transition note: In*

civilian life, pay grade and rank communicate very little to most employers. What matters is what you did, who you led, and what outcomes you produced — translate it.

EANGUS

Enlisted Association of the National Guard of the United States. Advocacy organization for National Guard enlisted members.

Entitlement (VA Home Loan)

The amount of the VA loan guarantee the government will provide on behalf of a veteran borrower. There is a "basic" entitlement of \$36,000 (mostly symbolic) and a "bonus" entitlement that allows loans above conforming loan limits without a down payment. *Transition note: You don't technically "use up" your entitlement permanently — it can be restored when a VA loan is paid off or, in some cases, when you sell the property.*

Entrepreneurial Operating System (EOS)

A business management framework from Gino Wickman's "Traction" that uses 6 components: Vision, People, Data, Issues, Process, Traction. Veterans with systems thinking backgrounds adapt to EOS quickly.

Equity

The portion of an asset you actually own outright, calculated as market value minus outstanding debt. In a home: if your house is worth \$300,000 and you owe \$220,000, you have \$80,000 in equity. *Transition note: Building equity through home ownership (especially house hacking with a VA loan) is one of the fastest legitimate wealth-building paths available to veterans with limited starting capital.*

ETS (Expiration Term of Service)

Army term for the date a service member's enlistment contract expires. The official separation date for enlistees. *Equivalent terms: PRD (Navy/Marine Corps "Projected Rotation Date"), DEROS (Air Force), EAOS (Navy).*

F

FITREP (Fitness Report)

The Navy and Marine Corps officer performance evaluation. Equivalent to the Army OER. *Transition note: Civilian employers don't review FITREPs, OERs, or NCOERs — you'll need to translate the narrative of your performance into quantified civilian achievement language.*

Fixed Expense

A recurring expense that stays constant month to month regardless of behavior: mortgage/rent, car payment, insurance premiums. Distinguished from variable expenses, which fluctuate. *Transition note: Minimizing fixed expenses is the fastest way to create margin — financial breathing room — in your budget.*

Freedom Architecture

A MISSION REBUILD course term. The intentional design of your life so that time, money, relationships, and energy align with your values and mission — not someone else's agenda. The opposite of letting your life happen to you.

Freedom Number

The monthly passive income amount that covers your entire cost of living. When your passive income equals or exceeds your monthly expenses, you have achieved financial independence. *Example: If you spend \$4,500/month, your freedom number is \$4,500/month from investments, real estate, or business income.*

Funding Fee (VA Home Loan)

A one-time fee charged at closing on a VA loan, ranging from 1.25% to 3.3% of the loan amount depending on down payment amount and whether it's a first or subsequent use. *Key exemption: Veterans with a service-connected disability rating of 10% or higher are exempt from the funding fee — potentially saving thousands of dollars.*

G**GI Bill (Post-9/11 / Chapter 33)**

VA education benefit for veterans who served at least 90 days on active duty after September 10, 2001, or were discharged for a service-connected disability. Covers tuition (up to state in-state rate or national cap), a monthly housing allowance, and book stipend. Maximum benefit: 36 months (or 48 months if combining Chapter 33 and 30). *See also: Yellow Ribbon Program, VET TEC.*

GWOT (Global War on Terror)

The collective term for U.S. military operations following the September 11, 2001 attacks, including Operations Enduring Freedom (Afghanistan), Iraqi Freedom (Iraq), and New Dawn. GWOT service is often relevant to VA PACT Act presumptive conditions and benefit eligibility.

H

House Hacking

Buying a property, living in one unit or room, and renting out the other units or rooms to offset or eliminate your housing cost. *Transition note: One of the most powerful wealth-building strategies for veterans because the VA Home Loan allows purchase of 1–4 unit properties with no down payment. You can live for free (or nearly free) while building equity and generating cash flow.*

Hypervigilance

A heightened state of alertness and sensitivity to potential threats in the environment. A survival-adaptive response in combat that can become disruptive in civilian contexts (crowded spaces, unexpected sounds, conflict). *Transition note: Hypervigilance is not a character flaw — it's a trained and sometimes trauma-related neurological state. It can be managed through therapy (particularly EMDR and CPT), physical regulation practices, and gradual exposure.*

I

Identity Foreclosure

A psychological concept (from Erik Erikson's theory of identity development) describing a state where a person commits to an identity — such as "soldier" or "Marine" — without fully exploring who they are outside of it. *Transition note: Many career service members experience identity foreclosure — their entire sense of self was built within the military structure. Separation forces a confrontation with identity that can be disorienting. The work of Module 1 directly addresses this.*

Imposter Syndrome

The persistent feeling that you are not as competent or qualified as others perceive you to be, and that you will eventually be exposed as a fraud. Extremely common among high-performing veterans entering new civilian environments. *Transition note: Veterans who led platoons and managed millions of dollars of equipment often feel like frauds when applying for civilian jobs. The competence is real — the self-doubt is the lie.*

Informational Interview

A conversation with a professional in a field or company you're interested in, for the purpose of gathering information and building a relationship — NOT to ask for a job directly. *Transition note: Veterans who grew up in a world where you were told your job were often unfamiliar with the civilian norm of networking through informational interviews. This is one of the most effective and underused job search tools available.*

Institutional Identity

A term used in social science to describe an identity that is entirely constructed within and dependent on a specific institution (military, prison, church). When the institution disappears, so does the identity anchor. *Transition note: The military is one of the most identity-forming institutions in human society. Veterans who served long careers are particularly vulnerable to institutional identity loss at separation.*

L

Lay Statement

See **Buddy Statement**.

Leverage

Using other people's time, money, skills, or systems to create returns beyond what you could create with your own resources alone. *Transition note: The military runs entirely on leverage — you commanded or were part of a unit that multiplied individual effort into collective capability. Financial leverage (debt used to acquire cash-flowing assets), time leverage (systems and automation), and people leverage (teams and employees) are the civilian applications.*

Leverage Stack

A MISSION REBUILD course term. The combination of financial, skill, relationship, and time leverage a veteran has built that allows them to produce outsized results relative to their effort input. *Building a leverage stack is the alternative to trading time for money indefinitely.*

Liability

Anything you owe: mortgage balance, car loan, credit card debt, student loans. Distinguished from an asset (what you own). *Key insight: A car is typically a depreciating asset — and an ongoing liability. A rental property can be both an asset and a tool to pay off the liability (mortgage) with someone else's money (rent).*

LTV (Loan-to-Value Ratio)

The ratio of a loan amount to the appraised value of the property. A \$240,000 mortgage on a \$300,000 home = 80% LTV. *Transition note: VA loans allow 100% LTV (no down payment) for eligible veterans. Conventional loans typically require 20% down to avoid PMI, or 3–5% with PMI.*

M

MGIB (Montgomery GI Bill / Chapter 30)

The predecessor to the Post-9/11 GI Bill. Veterans who contributed \$1,200 during service and meet service requirements receive a flat monthly payment for education. Can sometimes be combined with Chapter 33 for extended eligibility. *Transition note: Rarely the better option compared to Chapter 33 for most veterans, but understand which benefit you're entitled to before electing one.*

Mission Rebuild

The core framework of this course: treating civilian life transition as a deliberate, planned mission rather than something that happens to you. *Key principle: You don't just separate from the military — you build something new. The rebuild is the mission.*

MOOC (Massive Open Online Course)

Online courses available to large numbers of participants, often for free or at low cost. Platforms include Coursera, edX, LinkedIn Learning, and Udemy. *Transition note: MOOCs can be used to build civilian credentials in technology, business, data, and management without cost (using GI Bill or VR&E for paid programs, or free auditing for foundational learning).*

Moral Injury

A form of psychological distress that results from actions, or failure to act, in ways that violate a person's moral code. Distinct from PTSD, moral injury is rooted in guilt, shame, and spiritual conflict rather than fear. *Transition note: Many veterans carry moral injury without a clinical PTSD diagnosis. Symptoms include deep shame, withdrawal, recklessness, and difficulty feeling worthy of good things. Moral injury requires different treatment modalities than PTSD — values-based therapies and meaning-making are particularly effective.*

MOS (Military Occupational Specialty)

The Army and Marine Corps system for classifying a service member's primary job. *Examples: 11B (Infantryman), 25U (Signal Support Specialist), 68W (Health Care Specialist). Transition note: Never put your MOS code on a civilian resume without translation. "11B Infantry" means almost nothing to a civilian hiring manager — "Combat Team Leader" with achievement bullets does.*

N

NCO (Non-Commissioned Officer)

An enlisted service member in a leadership position: Army/Marine Corps Corporal through Sergeant Major; Navy Petty Officer 2nd Class through Master Chief; Air Force Staff Sergeant through Chief Master

Sergeant. *Transition note: The NCO is the backbone of military effectiveness — responsible for training, discipline, and welfare of junior enlisted. NCO leadership experience translates to operations manager, team lead, supervisor, and small business owner roles in civilian markets.*

NCOER (Non-Commissioned Officer Evaluation Report)

The Army's performance evaluation for NCOs (E-5 through E-9). Equivalent to the OER for officers. Completed by the rater (direct supervisor) and senior rater. *Transition note: The language in your NCOERs can be mined for material for your resume and STAR stories. Pull out the specific achievements and quantify them.*

Net Worth

Total assets minus total liabilities. The truest measure of financial health. *Transition note: Your net worth is the number you should track quarterly. It captures the full picture — income alone is not wealth. Two people earning \$80,000/year can have wildly different net worths based on what they own and what they owe.*

Nexus Letter

A medical opinion letter, written by a licensed medical provider, establishing that a veteran's current condition is "at least as likely as not" related to their military service. Used to support VA disability claims when service records don't explicitly document the condition. *Transition note: A nexus letter from a private, qualified physician can be the difference between an approved and denied claim. The VA's C&P examiner may be less familiar with your full service history than a private doctor you've worked with.*

O

O-1 through O-10

Officer pay grades. O-1 (2nd Lieutenant, Ensign, 2nd Lieutenant) through O-10 (General/Admiral). *Transition note: Officer rank translates well into executive and management roles in the civilian sector — but rank-based authority does not transfer. Influence must be earned differently in civilian environments.*

OER (Officer Evaluation Report)

The Army's formal performance evaluation for commissioned officers (O-1 through O-6). Completed annually and at key milestones. Equivalent to the NCOER for officers.

Ownership Mindset

A MISSION REBUILD course term. The belief that you are responsible for your outcomes — not the VA, not your employer, not the economy, not civilian society's failure to understand veterans. The discipline of

taking full responsibility for your life, decisions, and results without excuses. *This does not mean things weren't stacked against you. It means you choose to respond as if you control what happens next — because in the ways that matter most, you do.*

P

PACT Act

See resource list section. Sergeant First Class Heath Robinson Honoring our Promise to Address Comprehensive Toxics Act (2022). Expanded VA presumptive conditions for burn pit exposure and other toxic exposures. *Transition note: If you served in the Middle East after 9/11, this act likely expanded your VA eligibility. Do not delay reviewing it.*

P&T (Permanent and Total)

A VA disability determination indicating that a veteran's service-connected disability is both permanent (not expected to improve) and total (100%). P&T status triggers additional benefits: Dependents' Educational Assistance (DEA/Chapter 35), Commissary and Exchange access, and protection from rating reductions. *Transition note: If you are 100% rated and have a P&T determination, you should not receive a rating reduction letter — if you do, immediately contact your VSO.*

Passive Income

Income earned with minimal ongoing time investment — from investments, rental properties, business systems, or royalties. Distinguished from active income, which requires your direct labor. *Transition note: Building passive income is not passive to create. It requires significant upfront work, capital, or skill development. But once established, it provides financial freedom that no job alone can provide.*

PCS (Permanent Change of Station)

A military relocation to a new duty station, typically occurring every 2–3 years. *Transition note: The PCS cycle — constant moves, temporary communities, disposable relationships — is one of the hardest habits to shake in civilian life. Many veterans resist building community because they expect to move again. You're not moving on orders anymore. Build roots.*

Personal Brand

The deliberate reputation and identity you build in professional and public spaces — what you're known for and what people associate with your name. *Transition note: In the military, your brand was largely determined by your performance reports, your rank, and your unit. In civilian life, you must build and communicate your own brand — particularly on LinkedIn, in communities, and through the quality of your work.*

PGIB (Post-9/11 GI Bill)

See **GI Bill (Post-9/11 / Chapter 33)**.

PMI (Private Mortgage Insurance)

Insurance required by lenders when a borrower puts less than 20% down on a conventional mortgage. Protects the lender — not the borrower. Typically 0.5–1.5% of the loan amount annually. *Transition note: The VA Home Loan does not require PMI regardless of down payment. This is one of its most significant financial advantages.*

PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder)

A mental health condition that can develop after experiencing or witnessing traumatic events. Symptoms include intrusive memories, avoidance, negative mood and cognition changes, and hyperarousal. *Transition note: PTSD is service-connected and VA-compensable. It is a diagnosable medical condition, not a character flaw. If you meet the criteria, file for it. If you're not sure, get evaluated. Untreated PTSD does not improve on its own.*

R

Rating Decision

The VA's official written determination of a veteran's eligibility for compensation and the percentage rating assigned to each service-connected condition. *Transition note: Read every rating decision carefully. Look for conditions that were denied and understand why — many denials are overturnable with additional evidence.*

Resilience System

A MISSION REBUILD course term. The combination of five pillars — sleep, movement, nutrition, connection, and purpose — that together determine your capacity to handle stress, setbacks, and challenge without breaking. *The military gave you resilience training whether you recognized it as such or not. The civilian version requires intentional maintenance.*

Roth IRA

An individual retirement account funded with after-tax dollars, with tax-free growth and tax-free withdrawals in retirement. *Transition note: Veterans who leave service with lower incomes during transition years are often in a lower tax bracket — making Roth IRA contributions especially advantageous. Maximum contribution in 2024: \$7,000/year (\$8,000 if 50+).*

S

Secondary Service Connection

A VA disability claim in which a veteran's service-connected condition (primary) is shown to have caused or aggravated a new condition (secondary). The secondary condition then becomes service-connected as well. *Transition note: This is one of the most underutilized claims strategies. Example: knee injury (primary SC) → causes hip compensation issues and gait changes → hip condition is secondary SC. Get a thorough medical evaluation and ask your provider to document all related conditions.*

Service Connection

The legal basis for VA disability compensation. A condition is service-connected if it occurred during military service, was caused or aggravated by service, or is presumed to be related to service under established presumptive conditions. *Three elements required: (1) a current diagnosis, (2) an in-service event or aggravation, (3) a nexus (connection) between the two.*

SkillBridge

See the Resource List entry under Transition Resources. DOD program allowing transitioning service members to work with civilian employers for up to 180 days before separation while maintaining military pay and benefits.

SMC (Special Monthly Compensation)

Additional VA compensation beyond the standard disability rating table for veterans with certain severe disabilities — such as loss of use of a limb, the need for aid and attendance, or specific sensory losses. *Transition note: SMC can significantly increase monthly payments for veterans with severe disabilities. If you need help with daily activities, require a caregiver, or have specific limb or sensory losses, ask your VSO about SMC eligibility.*

STAR Method

Situation, Task, Action, Result. A structured storytelling framework for answering behavioral interview questions. *Transition note: Military veterans often default to describing their duties ("I was responsible for...") rather than their achievements ("I led a team that achieved X outcome, resulting in Y measurable result"). STAR format forces the achievement framing that civilian employers respond to.*

Subjective Experience (in claims context)

Non-quantifiable symptoms that a veteran reports but that may not appear on objective medical tests — pain level, fatigue, cognitive difficulties. Relevant in VA claims where the veteran's self-reported experience is part of the evidence. *Transition note: You are your own most credible witness about your own symptoms. Personal statements and buddy statements that describe the impact of your condition on daily life are legitimate and important evidence.*

T

TAP (Transition Assistance Program)

The mandatory pre-separation program provided by DOD covering VA benefits, job search, and financial planning basics. *See the Resource List for an honest assessment of TAP's value and limitations.*

TDY (Temporary Duty)

Army and Air Force term for temporary assignment away from a service member's permanent duty station. Equivalent to TDY is TAD (Temporary Additional Duty, Navy/Marine Corps). *Transition note: Veterans with extensive TDY/TAD history have experience managing independent work away from a home base — translatable as self-direction, adaptability, and remote execution capability.*

TSP (Thrift Savings Plan)

The federal government's retirement savings and investment plan, available to military members and federal civilian employees. Offers Traditional (pre-tax) and Roth options with low-cost index funds. Under BRS, the government matches up to 4% of base pay after 2 years. *Transition note: When you separate, you can leave your TSP where it is, roll it to an IRA (most common choice for more investment options), or roll it into a new employer's 401(k). Do not cash it out — you'll pay taxes plus a 10% penalty.*

U

Underemployment

The condition of working in a job that pays significantly less than your qualifications, experience, and skills warrant. Common among transitioning veterans who take the first available job rather than the right job. *Transition note: Underemployment is a choice — often made from financial desperation or impatience. Understanding your full market value before accepting a job offer is essential. The STAR stories, skills translation, and salary research in Module 4 address this directly.*

V

VA (Department of Veterans Affairs)

The federal agency responsible for providing veterans benefits, healthcare, and other services. Three main administrations: VBA (Veterans Benefits Administration), VHA (Veterans Health Administration), and NCA (National Cemetery Administration).

VA Disability Rating

A percentage assigned by the VA to a service-connected condition, representing the degree to which the condition impairs a veteran's ability to work and function. Ratings run from 0% to 100% in 10% increments. Combined ratings use VA "whole person" math, not simple addition. *Transition note: Your combined disability rating determines your monthly compensation amount and eligibility for other benefits (CHAMPVA, commissary access, state-specific veteran property tax exemptions, etc.). Know your rating, know what it means, and know how to increase it if it's inaccurate.*

Value Proposition

A clear statement of the specific value you offer to an employer or client — what problem you solve, for whom, and why you're the best option. *Transition note: Veterans often lack a clear civilian value proposition because they defaulted to describing what they did rather than the value they created. "I led teams" is a description. "I increased unit readiness from 72% to 94% in 60 days by redesigning the training schedule and requalifying 12 personnel" is a value proposition.*

Variable Expense

A recurring expense whose amount changes based on behavior or circumstances: groceries, dining, gas, entertainment. Contrasted with fixed expenses.

Veteran

As defined by federal law (38 U.S.C. § 101): a person who served in the active military, naval, or air service, and who was discharged or released under conditions other than dishonorable. *Transition note: Guard and Reserve members who were activated for federal service (Title 10 orders) meet the federal definition. State-only activations (Title 32) may or may not qualify depending on the specific benefit.*

VR&E (Vocational Rehabilitation & Employment / Chapter 31)

A VA program that helps veterans with service-connected disabilities prepare for, find, and maintain suitable employment. Can fund education (often with higher benefits than GI Bill), job training, business development, and independent living support. *Eligibility: 20%+ disability rating and an employment handicap, or any rating with a serious employment handicap. Transition note: VR&E can fund graduate school, professional certifications, or even business startup costs — and is significantly underutilized. If you have a 20%+ rating and education or employment goals, apply.*

VSO (Veterans Service Organization)

A nonprofit organization that provides free claims representation, advocacy, and support to veterans. Must be accredited by the VA to represent claimants. VSO service officers are arguably the most underutilized resource available to veterans. *Transition note: Never pay someone to file a basic VA disability claim. VSOs — DAV, VFW, American Legion, AMVETS, and others — provide this service for free. Paid claims agents and attorneys are appropriate for complex appeals, not initial filings.*

W

Whole Person

In VA claims context: the mathematical concept that each new disability rating reduces the remaining "healthy" percentage of the veteran, not the full 100%. This produces combined ratings lower than the sum of individual ratings. *Transition note: Use the VA combined ratings calculator at va.gov or find a VSO to run the math for you. Never assume your combined rating is simply your individual ratings added together.*

W-2 Income

Wages and salary earned as an employee, reported on IRS Form W-2. Contrasted with 1099 income (self-employment, freelance, contracts). *Transition note: VA disability compensation is NOT reportable income for federal tax purposes — it is tax-free. Your W-2 salary from a civilian employer is fully taxable.*

Y

Yellow Ribbon Program

A partnership between the VA and private colleges and universities in which the school agrees to cover the cost of tuition and fees exceeding the Post-9/11 GI Bill tuition cap, and the VA matches those contributions dollar-for-dollar. *Transition note: Yellow Ribbon can make expensive private universities essentially free for veterans. Before choosing a school, check whether it participates in Yellow Ribbon and how many students it covers — some schools limit participation slots.*

Z

Zero-Based Budget

A budgeting method in which every dollar of income is assigned a specific purpose — spending, saving, debt payment, or investing — so that income minus all allocations equals zero. No money is "left over" to

be spent mindlessly. *Transition note: The zero-based budget is the financial equivalent of mission planning — every resource has a job. It's the most effective approach for veterans who spent years operating under resource constraints and clear accountability systems.*

This glossary will expand as the course evolves. If you encounter a term not covered here, flag it in the course community and it will be added.

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